elections, and lead to a cessation of hostilities during the transition.[77] The dialogue failed to take off. Instead, Islamabad brokered the Peshawar Accord, leaving little space for India to maneuver the situation to its benefit. Nonetheless, as the Peshawar accord failed and Rabbani reached out to New Delhi in September 1992, and amidst growing tensions with Hekmatyar, the MEA called for an urgent renewal of the peace initiative under the UN.[78] India stated that 'the absence of any political process, leading to the settlement acceptable to all sections of the Afghan people, has accentuated sectarian and ethnic tensions which could seriously undermine Afghanistan's unified character as a nation-state'.[79]

The UN's failure to broker peace, both in 1988 and 1992, raised serious doubts about its conflict resolution capacity. This was also the time when former Yugoslavia broke into five different states between 1989 and 1992; the Nagorno-Karabakh war was raging since 1988, and a civil war broke out in Tajikistan in which the *Jamiat-e-Islami* was actively involved. In December 1993, the UNGA adopted Resolution 48/208 requesting the Secretary-General to dispatch a special mission to Afghanistan that could assess the situation and find out how the UN can assist Afghanistan.[80] Resultantly, Mahmoud Mestiri became Sevan's successor as the UNSG's special representative to Afghanistan in February 1994. India's response, despite its calls for a renewed UN initiative, was lukewarm: 'A new peace initiative launched by the United Nations under the Special Envoy of the UN Secretary General Ambassador Mahmoud Mestiri is underway. But prospects for a peaceful political settlement in the near future still remain uncertain', remarked the MEA.[81]

The difference between India and the UN's thinking was underlined in an exchange between British secretary of state for foreign and commonwealth affairs, Douglas Hurd, and foreign secretary Srinivasan at the Hyderabad House in Delhi in mid-1994 (in the presence of foreign minister Dinesh Singh, who could not speak due to a stroke that left him partly paralysed). London had supported Mestiri's settlement plan on Afghanistan throughout, and was keen on seeing Rabbani step down (allowing Hekmatyar to assume power). When Hurd expressed these views to Srinivasan, the latter lashed out that Rabbani, from India's perspective, was the best possible alternative in the circumstances, and